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Abstract

For those of you who hear a voice when you read these words, and those of you who can conjure one, – there is a sense in which we might regard the audio you hear to be the result of distributed synthesis.

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1 Confluences of Practice & Constitutive Encounters

This chapter aims to survey the creative practitioners with whom I have forged constitutive identifications, and to explicate the sets of commitments to which, through those identificatory processes, I have become implicitly subscribed. Although communities are an important facet of this mechanism, I have avoided framing this section as “Community of Practice” to allow for the way in which fashioning, facilitating, and understanding of exactly such communities has itself become, in many cases, the *subject* of creative practice, rather than its *context*, per se.

1.i Brian Crabtree & Kelli Cain

Encountering the work of Brian Crabtree and Kelli Cain felt like a breath of fresh air. Yes, the hardware music controllers they produced under the company name *monome* featured well-proportioned, minimalist design, good ergonomics and impressive craftsmanship, but what really distinguished them most starkly was their embodiment of a very particular design principle: the objects were *open-ended*.

It is worth spending a moment to unpack some of the heavy-lifting the term “open-ended” is doing here. Hegemonically, design practices inevitably begin with *empathy* – a fleshed-out picture of how and why the end-user will engage with the object of design. (Norman, 2013) By holding this picture strongly in mind through the design process, the developed object caters well for those actual users whose needs and motivations fit the designer’s imaginary depiction. In this way we can understand that designed objects always carry with them a *subject position*: the shape of the type of human the user needs to be (or, importantly,

become) in order for the designed object to be meaningful to them. (DiSalvo, 2012; Morton, 2011; Suchman, 2007)

What made the encounter so refreshing was the way the subject position implied by these objects seemed devoid of assumptions regarding what they should be used *for*, beyond the bare mechanics of the object’s affordances – both physical (button presses, encoder rotations, LED brightness levels, etc.) and connective (open sound control). We can understand this conceptual manouvre to be both a re-centering of systems level thinking, as proposed by Bánáthy (1996), and a simultaneous, reciprocal de-centering of the ossified, vetruvian human figure, as described by Braidotti (2019). At a systems level, we can trace what is embedded to be a technological orientation inherited from the project of *open source*. At the subject position level, I would like to argue that this teleological reduction embeds an expanded creative horizon, furnished with an extended set of possibilities regarding what *work* can be.

1.i.a Open Source & the Deployment of Utopia

*... the sharing of a creation’s source code is ... an anarchic
act of setting free, sending off, and waiting to see how an
idea or instrument may evolve in the hands and minds of
an international community.*

— Crabtree (2024, p. 467)

It is my contention that open source, like *synthesis*, is best understood as a material-discursive practice. Both practices implicitly seek to untether the project of modernism from the project of capitalism, inasmuch as they represent an entanglement of technical knowledges and production logics with discursively responsive sets of normative commitments – a feature notably abstracted to near-oblivion by the day-to-day mechanics of capitalist work relations. (Fisher, 2020) This normative freedom sits uncomfortably amongst the predatory injunctions of capital which inevitably function to exploit and extract value from exactly this system’s capacity to facilitate autonomous, and therefore unpaid, forms of work.

In this way we might understand the material plane of this material-discursive practice to display the properties of a complex system, replete with both structural vulnerabilities, often

resulting in sudden shifts of seismic proportions; and adaptability, which we must sensibly attribute to the tenacity of the utopian commitments structuring its discursive articulations. (Holland, 2003) Because of the combined effect of its unpredictability and tenacity, much discourse has emerged regarding the ways in which FOSS infrastructure articulates with an economic field dominated by massive technology corporations (Asparouhova, 2020), and how open source nomenclature can produce paradoxically extractative material effects (Tkacz, 2015).

It is with the complexity of this context in mind that we should understand monome’s commitment to open source as not merely an *anarchic* gesture, as Crabtree himself describes it (2024, p. 467), but also as a de-centering of the locus of design from a human orientation, to a systems orientation. (Suchman, 2007) Rather than insinuating that the object can take the user all the way to some enclosed, pre-fabricated utopia, the object, in monome’s own words, “does nothing”. Any utopian potential the user might see in the object then becomes contingent on the user inhabiting an empowered subject position either equipped with forms of technological literacies required to unlock that potential, or, importantly, the disposition to learn them.

In this way we can therefore understand utopia to be deployed not as marketing, but in the set of commitments that constitute the objects’ subject position. In addition to implicating specific forms of work, these utopian logics, now housed in the constitutive commitments of users’ subjectivities, have the opportunity to become operable in a sustained manner, at the point of these material objects’ discursive articulation, via the action of their users’ language – a feedback loop which, as mentioned earlier, is important in imbuing the material-discursive system with the attribute of adaptability.

1.i.b Multiple Lineages

*... there are multiple lineages
and paths being traveled herein.*

— Crabtree (2024, p. 465)

We might trace monome’s commitment to open source back to when the pair met at

University of California San Diego. Crabtree studied under the tutelage of Miller Puckette and Tom Erbe, who are notable here not merely because of the way in which their design thinking influenced monome, but because of their direct influence on my own creative practice and the project of distributed synthesis more specifically.

1.i.c Mycelial Creativity

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